



Phantom ringing catching up quick

After braving a pandemic, invasive work from home, and way too many online classes, we have now got a new problem

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I imagine a time when you are in your room, engrossed in a task, when your phone starts vibrating. But did it vibrate really?

After expecting the call for close to two hours, which were spent looking at your phone every fifteen minutes to check if there were any phone calls, you almost give up. Just when you are too tired to stay awake, you hear your phone vibrate faintly and then ring. The subsequent tragedy that unfolds is in two parts: it wasn't a phone call that got your phone vibrating; in fact, your phone was not vibrating at all. The vibrations, if any, were all in your head.

Scientists and researchers like to call these false auditory sensations phantom vibrations – an ugly trick that our mind plays at us every now and

then, and we start hallucinating our cell phones buzzing.

ENTER RINGXIETY

For some people, it is not the vibrations, but the ringtone of their mobile phones that they imagine hearing, hence the name goes phantom ringing. According to a 2018 study published in the Indian Journal of Psychological Medicine, background phantom sensations like phantom vibration (PV) and phantom ringing (PR) – the sensations of vibration and ringing of the phone when they are not, respectively – are among the latest in the category of “technopathology” to receive global attention. Both these syndromes are fairly common. A research suggests that nine of ten mobile phone users suffer from them, and briefly, they were clubbed together into ‘ringxiety’, a portmanteau that blends ring with anxiety.

The man who coined this word, David J. Laramie, was also, the first

scholar to formally record this phenomenon. In the summer of 2007, he submitted his dissertation to the California School of Professional Psychology. In that it was mentioned that as many as two-thirds of 320 adult mobile-phone users, in an online survey reported that they had heard their mobiles ringing when they weren't. For many Gen Zs and young adults, it is the first time in their young lives that they're having a brush with ringxiety.

Wajiha Haider was in Bangalore, working from home for Qatar-based ed-tech start-up Wise, when she got her first phantom ring. It was March 2021, the deadly second wave of Covid-19 had again pushed everyone behind the doors, and work from home was now a thing. From dawn to dusk, the twenty-two year old marketing manager was glued to her mobile phone and laptop, and rarely stepped outside the dizzy world of the internet.

“So I was in the kitchen, okay,” she told, over a half-an-hour long call, “my phone was with me only, I was looking for a recipe on YouTube, so I was sure it was not my phone vibrating.”